

MERCEDES BENZ S-CLASS

Engine: 2,999 cc, six-cylinder, petrol plug-in hybrid
Max. power: 435 bhp
Peak torque: 680 Nm
Gearbox: 9-speed AT
Wheelbase: 3,106 mm
LxHxW: 5,194x1, 921x1, 503 mm
Fuel tank: 67 litres
0-100 kmph: 5.7 seconds
Top speed: 250 kmph
Price: Rs 2.2 crore (ex-showroom)

Bing and Google Gemini.

With 10 external cameras, five radars and 12 ultrasonic sensors, not only can the S-Class recognise parking spots before actually coming to them, it can also park by itself in non-conventional spaces, with or without differentiating lines, covered with grass or in between trees. It can also park itself at twice the speed it did earlier.

All the engines are upgraded and in the case of the top-of-the-line V8, this is perhaps the biggest work done on an internal combustion engine since the pandemic. The line-up starts with the EVO versions of the inline-six cylinder petrol and diesel engines. While all engines are mild hybrids, there are also two versions of plug-in hybrids, again powered by the inline-six, with 100 km of electric-only range.

Moreover, someone has finally gotten it right with regards to phone slots. Now, there are two charging pads accessible by the driver and passenger. The steering wheel is more tactile, too.

At the rear, instead of a single tablet for the rear seat passengers, each gets their own controller in the form of a removable smartphone-like device. The screens for rear passengers are also bigger and have an integrated webcam.

The entire climate control system has gone electronic, with the vents now opening and closing electrically and having numerous settings where the vents and the air flow get adjusted by themselves according to presets.

The AIRMATIC suspension system is now intelligent, and the rear wheel steering can turn up to an angle of 10 degrees, making short work of U-turns and cutting the turning circle. Driving the car feels more agile and nimble. It feels most different in its handling of really bad road surfaces and speed bumps.

All the engine variants, including the plug-in hybrids, get up to the top speed of 250 kmph with nonchalance. The 450e that will be launched in India features total output of 435 bhp and peak torque of 680 Nm. It will get up to 100 kmph in 5.7 seconds and now features a 27.8 kWh battery pack that can drive the car up to 108 km and a top speed of 140 kmph on electricity alone. The only drawback of the plug-in hybrids is that the boot space gets compromised as the floor of the boot is raised.

Overall, while the car is not revolutionary, it is better than before in every aspect. Mercedes has got the architecture right to build on for the future. ■